Local Hub

How to Prevent Costly Water Damage at Home

A practical guide to the leaks you can stop, the checks worth doing, and what to do in the first hour if water gets in. With insights drawn from leading research and field experts.



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Start here

Water damage is one of the most common and most expensive problems a household can face. It rarely announces itself. The good news: most of it is preventable, and the habits that prevent it are simple.

Do these three things today

1. Find your main shut-off

Walk to the valve, make sure it turns, and show everyone at home where it is.

2. Save two numbers

Put a trusted plumber and a restoration company in your phone. It beats a frantic search at 2 a.m.

3. Film your home

Walk through each room with your phone and store the video in the cloud.

A small drip behind a wall, a clogged gutter or a worn hose can go unnoticed for weeks. By the time you see a stain, the damage underneath is often well established. This guide is written for homeowners and renters, with no technical background needed. It will help you:

- Understand where household water damage usually starts.
- Check your home with a short monthly and seasonal routine.
- React quickly and calmly during the first hour after a leak.
- Decide when it is time to call a professional.
- Prepare for a conversation with your insurer.

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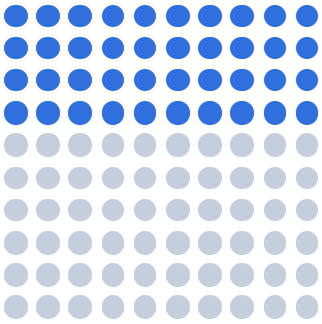
How to use this guide

Read pages 5 to 9 once to learn the trouble spots. Print or save the checklist on pages 11 and 12 and set a repeating calendar reminder. Keep page 13 somewhere easy to find, on the fridge or in your phone, so you know exactly what to do if water appears at 2 a.m.

This is general information to help you be prepared. It is not a substitute for advice from a licensed plumber, electrician, restoration professional or your insurance provider, who can assess your specific situation.

Why it matters

Fire gets the headlines. Water is the one most likely to reach your door.



More than 4 in 10

home insurance claims handled by Allstate Canada from 2021 to 2025 were for water damage.

The Insurance Bureau of Canada said back in 2017 that insurers were already paying out more for water than for fire.

Sources 1, 2. One insurer's claims; dots show about 40 of every 100.

Less costly than fire, but far more common

How often: claims per 100 insured homes, per year

Wind and hail	2.80
Water and freezing	**1.50**
Fire and lightning	0.23
Theft	0.12

How much: average paid per claim (US$)

Fire and lightning	$88,170
Water and freezing	**$15,400**
Wind and hail	$14,747
Theft	$5,524

A water claim happens more than six times as often as a fire claim, and the average one pays out US$15,400.

Source 3: Triple-I, US homeowners insurance, 2019 to 2023 average. "All other" causes left out.

A flood can cost far more than the fix

$43,000: average basement flood repair, 2018

Under $250: many of the recommended fixes

Source 4: Intact Centre on Climate Adaptation, University of Waterloo, Canadian dollars. Bars drawn to scale. No step guarantees a dry basement.

Why speed matters

Water spreads further and faster than most people expect. Drywall, insulation, carpet and wood start absorbing moisture right away, and mould can begin to grow within a day or two in damp conditions. Acting early usually means a smaller job and a smaller bill.

Meet the experts

We went through published research and field guidance from three people who have spent years on this problem. Their best ideas appear in the dark boxes throughout this guide.

BF

Blair Feltmate

Head of the Intact Centre on Climate Adaptation and professor at the University of Waterloo, at the time of his 2019 report

His team assessed more than 500 homes in Ontario and Saskatchewan to find what actually stops basement floods.

Big idea: protection is not a renovation. He says "any homeowner who lives where it rains can easily and cost-effectively deploy simple measures." Most can be done over a weekend.

DS

Dan Sandink

Author of the Handbook for Reducing Basement Flooding, Institute for Catastrophic Loss Reduction

His handbook comes from a research institute backed by Canada's insurers, and cities such as Windsor and Brantford share it with residents.

Big idea: small details decide whether a system works. Where a downspout ends and how you test a pump matter as much as owning the equipment. And no home is ever at zero risk, so plan for what happens if water gets in.

RT

Richard Trethewey

Plumbing and heating expert on the TV series This Old House, from a Boston plumbing family in the trade since 1902

He has spent decades on camera showing homeowners how plumbing really works.

Big idea: assume any connection can fail, and make failure small. Local shut-off valves, automatic washer valves and leak sensors turn a flood into a nuisance.

A note on sources

The insights in this guide are summarized from each expert's public work, listed on page 18. These experts did not write, review or endorse this guide, and they have no connection to Local Hub.

The five trouble spots

Five areas account for a large share of household water problems. Know them, and you know where to look.

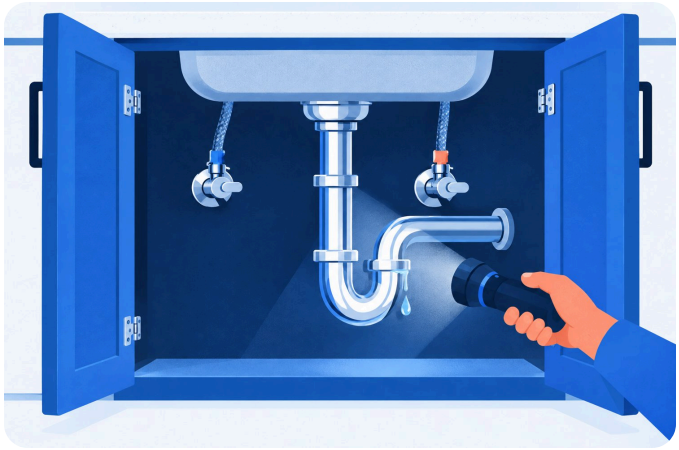


1. **Pipes and fittings**
   Under sinks, behind toilets, inside walls
2. **Appliances and hoses**
   Washer, water heater, dishwasher, fridge
3. **Roof, gutters, exterior**
   Shingles, flashing, downspouts, grading
4. **Sump pump and drainage**
   Pit, float switch, discharge pipe, floor drains
5. **Frozen pipes**
   Exterior walls, attics, garages, crawl spaces
+ **Other quiet leaks**
   Caulking, seals, ice dams, irrigation (page 9)

Three ways water reaches a basement

Overland: surface water pours in through windows, doors or window wells. **Infiltration:** water in the ground seeps through foundation cracks and floors. **Sewer backup:** an overloaded sewer pushes water up through your drains. Insurance can treat each one differently. (Source 5)

1 Pipes and plumbing fittings



Supply lines, drain lines and the joints between them wear out. Corrosion, loose fittings, high water pressure and age all contribute. Leaks under sinks, behind toilets and inside walls are the classic hidden culprits.

Warning signs

Water stains on ceilings or walls, bubbling paint, a musty smell, the sound of running water when nothing is on, or a water bill that creeps up for no clear reason.

Prevent it

Look under sinks monthly, know where your main shut-off valve is, and ask a plumber to check pressure if fixtures seem noisy or hoses wear quickly.

EXPERT INSIGHT · RICHARD TRETHEWEY

Don't let one leak shut down the whole house

Trethewey calls a leak in the plumbing system catastrophic, and argues that bathrooms should have their own branch shut-off valve. Without one, any problem means turning off water to the entire home. If you are renovating, ask your plumber to add local valves.

Source 7: interview in Plumber magazine

2 Appliances and their hoses

Washing machines, dishwashers, refrigerators with ice makers, water heaters and humidifiers all connect to your water supply. Rubber hoses harden and crack over time, and a failed hose or tank can release a lot of water quickly.



Warning signs

Bulging or cracked hoses, rust or moisture around connections, puddles near the appliance, or a water heater that is leaking or corroded at the base.

Prevent it

Inspect hoses at least twice a year, consider braided stainless-steel replacements, leave a little space behind appliances so you can see the connections, and replace hoses and water heaters on the manufacturer's suggested schedule.

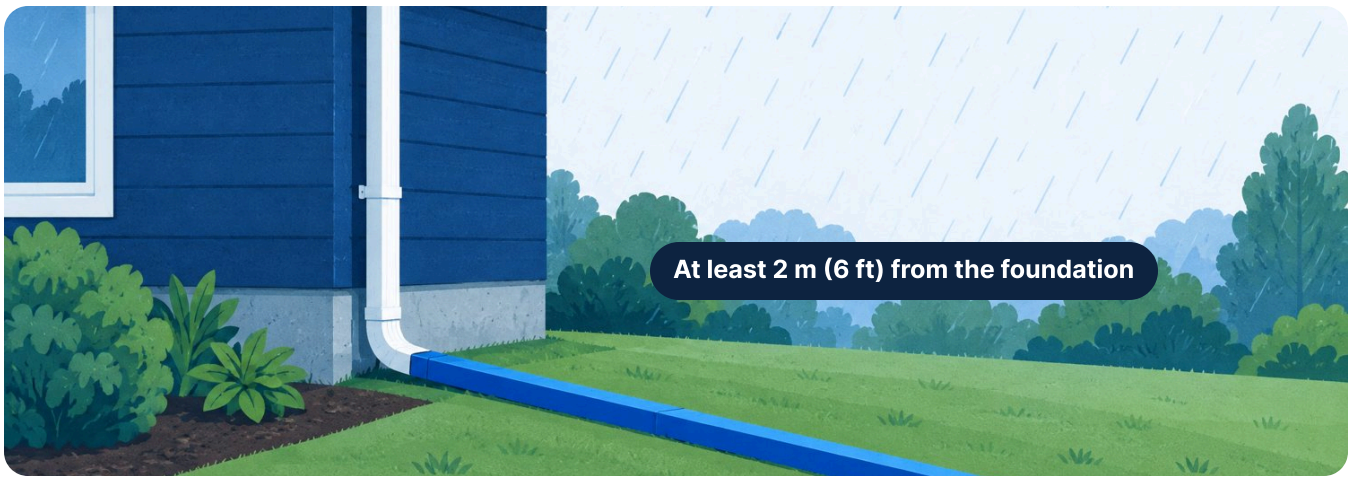
EXPERT INSIGHT · RICHARD TRETHEWEY

Let a valve and a sensor stand guard

On This Old House, Trethewey installs an automatic washer valve that opens only while the machine runs, so a burst hose cannot keep flowing. A small sensor on the floor behind the washer can close it too, for overflows and clogged drains. It may even lower your insurance premium, so ask your provider.

Source 8: This Old House

3 The roof, gutters and exterior



Missing or lifted shingles, damaged flashing around chimneys and vents, and clogged gutters let rain and melting snow find a way in. Water that pools against the foundation can also seep into basements.

Warning signs

Stains on upper-floor ceilings, damp attic insulation, shingles in the yard after a storm, overflowing gutters, or downspouts that dump water next to the house.

Prevent it

Clear gutters in spring and fall, point downspouts well away from the foundation, and have the roof looked at after severe weather.

EXPERT INSIGHT · DAN SANDINK

Where the water lands matters as much as where it falls

Sandink's handbook says to send downspout water at least 1.8 metres (6 ft) from the home, over lawn or garden rather than a driveway or walkway. Soil soaks it up. Pavement just sends it somewhere else. Before you disconnect a downspout from an underground pipe, check your city's rules.

Source 5: Handbook for Reducing Basement Flooding

4 Sump pumps and basement drainage



If your home has a sump pump, it is your basement's last line of defence, and it tends to fail exactly when it is needed: during heavy rain or a fast thaw. Power cuts, stuck float switches and clogged inlets are common reasons.

Warning signs

A pump that runs constantly or not at all, strange noises, standing water in the pit, or damp patches on basement floors and walls.

Prevent it

Every few months, pour a bucket of water into the pit to confirm the pump switches on and empties it. Clean the pit, check the discharge pipe is clear, and ask about a battery backup. Keep floor drains clear too.

EXPERT INSIGHT · DAN SANDINK

A pump without backup is a fair-weather friend

The storms that fill your pit can also knock out your power. Sandink's handbook suggests a battery-powered second pump in the same pit, set to start if the water rises past the main pump's level. It also warns that sump pumps are prone to blockage and failure without routine checks.

Source 5: Handbook for Reducing Basement Flooding

5 Frozen pipes



When water freezes it expands, and a pipe that freezes can split. The damage often shows up only when the ice thaws and water pours out. Pipes in exterior walls, attics, garages, crawl spaces and under sinks on cold walls are most at risk.

Warning signs

A trickle or no water from a tap during very cold weather, frost on visible pipes, or odd smells from drains.

Prevent it

Insulate exposed pipes, disconnect and drain outdoor hoses before winter, shut off and drain outdoor taps if you can, and leave cabinet doors open under sinks on exterior walls on the coldest nights.

Going away this winter?

Keep the heating on. The American Red Cross says no lower than 55°F (about 13°C), and to hold the same temperature day and night during a cold snap. A slightly higher heating bill is far cheaper than a burst pipe. (Source 9)

If a pipe is frozen but not yet burst

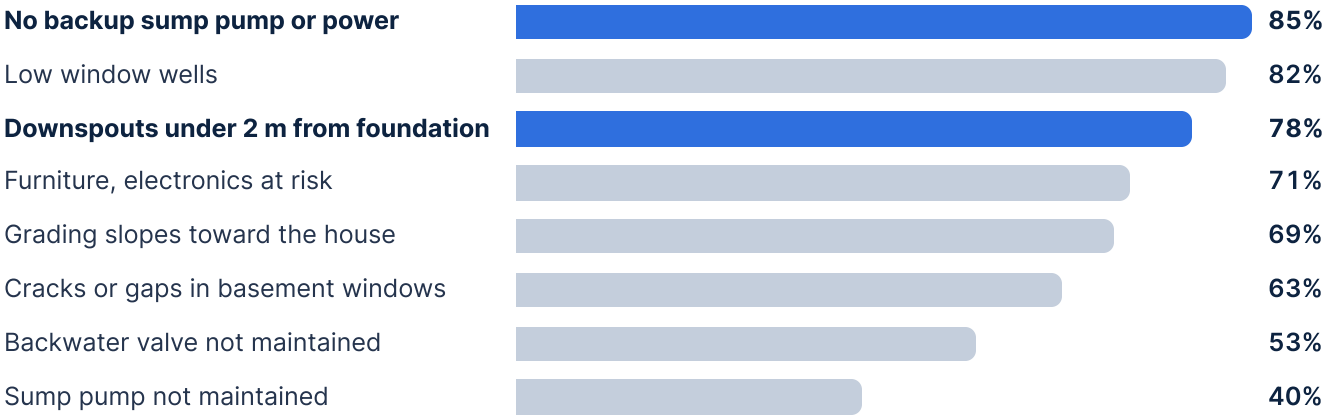
Open the tap slightly, and gently warm the area with a hair dryer or warm towels, working from the tap back towards the frozen section. Never use an open flame. If you cannot find the frozen section, cannot reach it, or the pipe has already split, shut off the water at the main valve and call a plumber.

Other things worth watching

Failed caulking around tubs and showers, overflowing toilets, window and door seals, ice dams on the roof edge, and plant pots or irrigation lines close to the foundation can all quietly let water in.

Where homes fall short

When assessors visited homes in southern Ontario, the same gaps kept showing up. Most of them are quick to close.



Source 4: Intact Centre on Climate Adaptation, share of homes assessed in Ontario, 2017 to 2018. Highlighted: the two gaps covered on pages 7 and 8.

EXPERT INSIGHT · BLAIR FELTMATE

Start at $0 and work your way up

Feltmate's team found the barrier is usually knowledge, not money: over 60% of the actions homeowners took cost under $500. After an assessment, 79% of residents acted on at least one recommendation. Their three-step ladder below is the simplest plan we found.

Source 4: Intact Centre on Climate Adaptation

$0
Do it yourself, twice a year

Maintain what you have
Clear the nearest storm drain, clean gutters, check plumbing and appliances, test the sump pump, clean the backwater valve.

Under $250
Do it yourself

Simple upgrades
Window well covers, downspout and sump extensions of 2 m, watertight storage, clear floor drains, flood alarms.

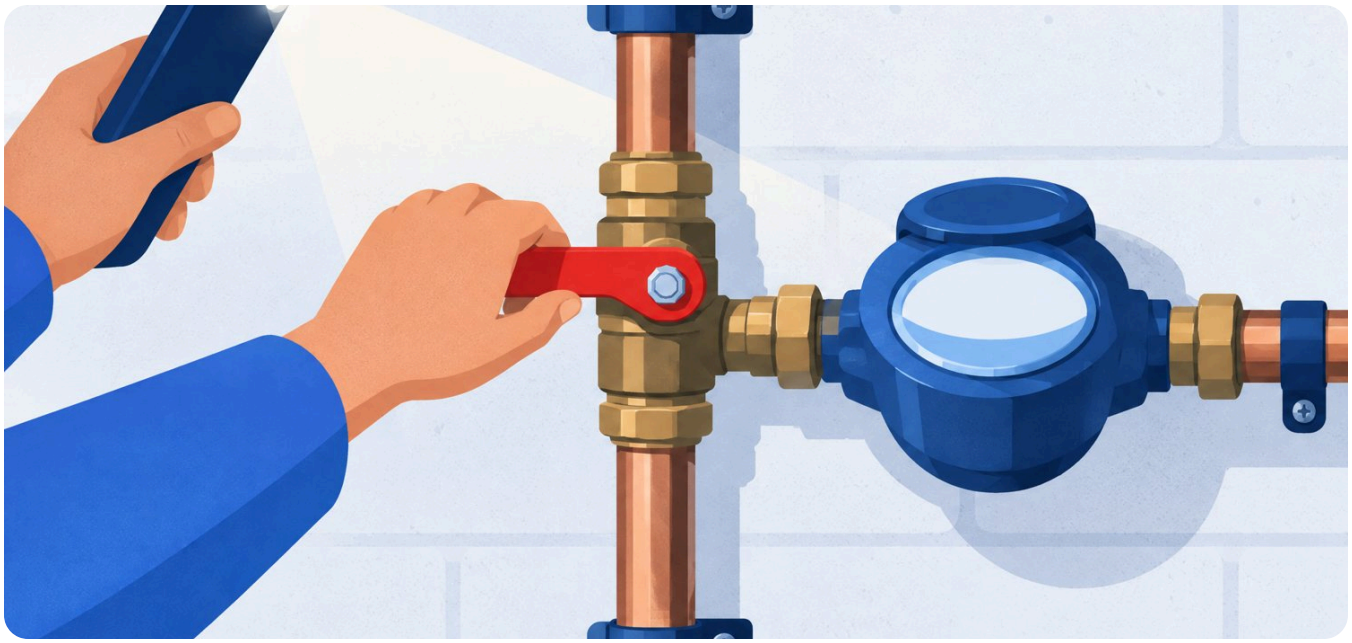
Over $250
Work with a contractor

Bigger upgrades
Raised window wells, better grading, a backwater valve, a backup sump pump and battery. Check permits and city subsidies first.

Adapted from Source 6. Not every step suits every home, and none guarantees a dry basement.

Your monthly check

Fifteen minutes a month beats a weekend of cleanup. Print this page or save it to your phone.



Every month

- [ ] Look under kitchen and bathroom sinks for drips, moisture or swelling in the cabinet base.
- [ ] Check around toilets, tubs and showers for soft spots, discoloured caulk or water on the floor.
- [ ] Glance at the washing machine and dishwasher hoses and the area around the water heater.
- [ ] Look at the ceiling and the basement walls for new stains or a damp smell.

The two-hour meter test

Read your water meter before and after a couple of hours when no water is used. If it moves, there may be a leak. It is the easiest way to catch one hiding inside a wall.

Renting?

Use this same list, and tell your landlord promptly about any leak, standing water or drainage problem.

Your seasonal check

Four short lists. Add each one to your calendar now and let the reminder do the remembering.

Spring

- [ ] Clean gutters and check downspouts drain away from the house.
- [ ] Test the sump pump with a bucket of water.
- [ ] Inspect the roof from the ground for lifted or missing shingles.
- [ ] Reconnect and check outdoor hoses and taps for leaks.
- [ ] Check basement walls and floors after the thaw.
- [ ] Clean your backwater valve, if you have one.

Summer

- [ ] Inspect appliance hoses and replace any that look worn.
- [ ] Check the grading around the foundation. Soil should slope away.
- [ ] Look at caulking around tubs, showers and windows.
- [ ] Flush the water heater if the manufacturer recommends it.
- [ ] Make sure floor drains are clear before storm season.

Fall

- [ ] Clean gutters again once leaves have dropped.
- [ ] Disconnect and drain outdoor hoses; drain outdoor taps if possible.
- [ ] Insulate exposed pipes in garages, attics and crawl spaces.
- [ ] Check window, door and vent seals before winter.
- [ ] Locate your main shut-off valve and make sure it turns.

Winter

- [ ] Keep the heat on, even if you are away.
- [ ] Open cabinet doors on exterior walls during cold snaps.
- [ ] Let a tap drip slightly on the coldest nights.
- [ ] Clear snow and ice away from the foundation and vents.
- [ ] Check the attic for damp insulation or ice dams.

Keep your receipts

Each time you replace a hose or add a battery backup, photograph the receipt and save it with your home inventory. Those records help if you ever need to make a claim.

The first hour after a leak

Stay calm and work through these steps in order. Your safety comes first, then the water, then the paperwork.

Safety first

If water is near electrical outlets, appliances, a fuse box or light fixtures, or the ceiling is sagging or bulging, stay out of the area. Switch off power at the breaker only if you can reach it safely and without stepping in water, and call a professional. When in doubt, leave and call for help.

1. **Stop the water.** Close the shut-off valve for the leaking fixture or appliance, or the main water valve for the house.
2. **Make it safe.** Keep people and pets away from standing water and wet electrics. If water may have reached outlets or the panel, do not touch them.
3. **Take photos and video.** Before moving anything, record the source, the affected areas and damaged belongings. Wide shots and close-ups both help.
4. **Limit the spread.** Mop or soak up standing water with towels, a wet/dry vacuum or buckets. Lift small items and rugs off wet floors; place foil or plastic under furniture feet.
5. **Move valuables.** Take electronics, documents, photos and anything irreplaceable to a dry room. Leave heavy or fixed items where they are.
6. **Start air movement.** If it is safe, open windows and run fans to help drying. Avoid using household vacuums on large amounts of water.
7. **Call for help.** Contact a licensed plumber if a pipe or fixture needs repair, and a restoration company if there is more than a small puddle. Then call your insurance provider (page 17).

My main shut-off is

My plumber's number

My restoration company

My insurer and policy number

The clock after a leak

The first day decides how big the job gets. Here is what you are racing against.

First minutes
Stop the water. Keep everyone away from wet electrics.

First hour
Record the damage, limit the spread, move valuables, make your calls.

24 to 48 hours
The EPA's target: dry water-damaged areas and items in this window to prevent mould.

After that
Have hidden moisture checked. Keep your claim file up to date.

Source 10: US EPA, A Brief Guide to Mold, Moisture and Your Home.

Don't

- Don't use heat to rush-dry materials.
- Don't throw away damaged items until you have documented them.
- Don't assume the problem is over once the surface looks dry. Moisture can remain inside walls and floors.

EXPERT INSIGHT · DAN SANDINK

Plan for the flood you hope never comes

Sandink's handbook is frank: even with every measure in place, some risk always remains. So reduce what a flood can reach. Raise important items off the basement floor on blocks or shelves, and keep documents and keepsakes in watertight plastic containers, or better yet upstairs.

Source 5: Handbook for Reducing Basement Flooding

What about mould?

The EPA says that in most cases you can clean a mouldy patch yourself if it is under about 10 square feet (roughly 3 ft by 3 ft). For anything larger, or for damage from sewage or other contaminated water, call a professional.

When to call a pro

Many small drips are fine for a confident DIYer. Some situations are not. Three questions will tell you which one you have.

Can you stop the water yourself?
No: call now

Is it near electrics, or is a ceiling sagging?
Yes: get out and call

Is it sewage, or has it been wet for over a day or two?
Yes: call today

Reasonable to handle yourself

- A small drip from a tap or an accessible under-sink connection
- Replacing a washing machine hose with the water off
- Mopping up a small spill or overflow
- Clearing a simple slow drain
- Cleaning gutters at ground level or from a safe, stable ladder

Call a professional

- Water you can't stop, or a main shut-off that won't turn
- Water near electrics, or a sagging or bulging ceiling
- A burst or frozen pipe inside a wall or ceiling
- Sewage or grey water backing up
- A leaking or damaged water heater
- Water present more than a day or two, or mould you can't easily clean
- Roof leaks, or anything that needs working at height



Which kind of pro?

Each trade solves a different part of the problem, and a big leak may need more than one.

Plumber
Finds and fixes the source: pipes, fixtures, hoses, water heaters, sump pumps and drains.

Water-damage restoration company
Removes water, dries the structure with professional equipment, and handles cleanup and mould concerns.

Roofer
Repairs shingles, flashing and ice-dam problems.

Electrician
Checks any wiring, outlets or panel that may have been exposed to water.

Questions to ask before you hire

- [ ] Are you licensed and insured in my area? Can you show proof?
- [ ] Do you offer emergency service, and how soon can someone arrive?
- [ ] Can I have a written estimate, and what could change the price?
- [ ] Will you give me photos and a written report for my records?

EXPERT INSIGHT · BLAIR FELTMATE

A second pair of eyes pays off

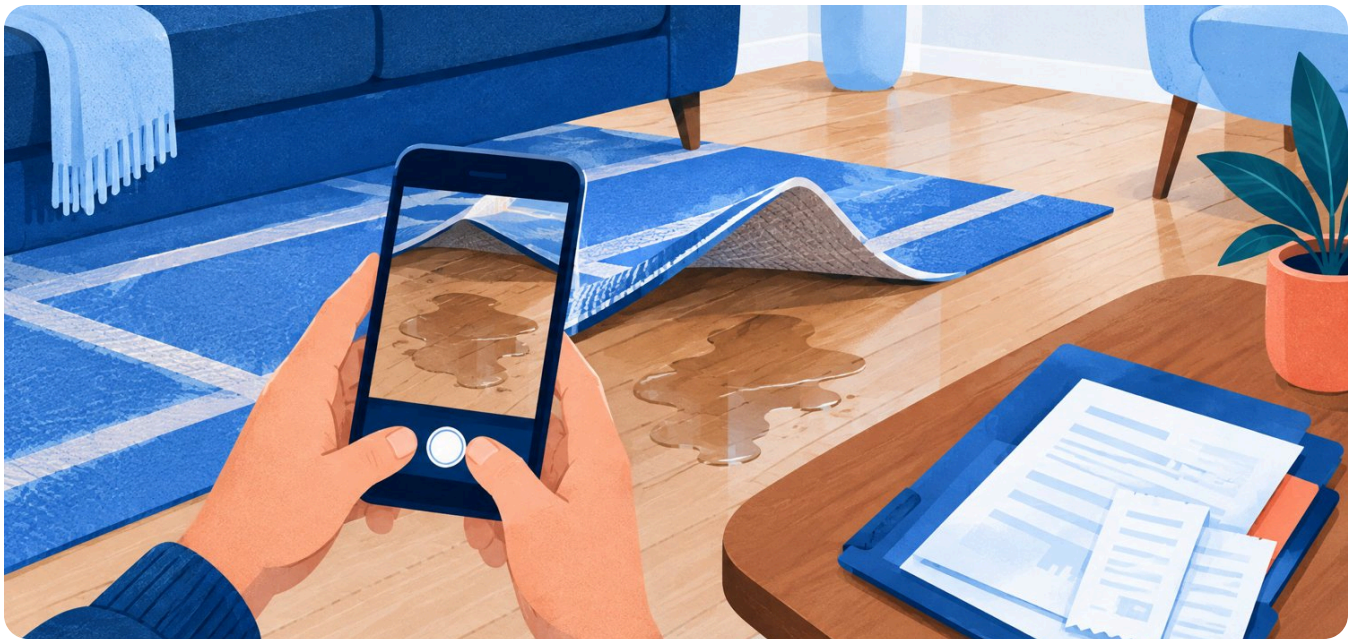
Feltmate's program found that direct conversations with people trained in flood risk were the most effective way to get residents to act. Reading helps, but a walk-through helps more. Ask a plumber or other trusted pro to look around your home with this guide in hand.

Source 4: Intact Centre on Climate Adaptation

Local Hub tip
Save a trusted plumber's and restoration company's numbers in your phone today. It beats a frantic search at 2 a.m.

Insurance tips

General suggestions to help you be organized. Policies differ widely, so check your own policy wording and talk to your provider or broker.



Before anything happens

- **Read your policy** so you know which types of water damage it mentions, and which it may not. Sewer backup, overland flooding and groundwater are often treated separately.
- **Ask about optional coverage and deductibles,** so there are no surprises later.
- **Keep a home inventory.** Film each room and its contents, and store it in the cloud, not just on the phone.
- **Keep records** of maintenance, repairs and receipts, such as hose replacements or a sump pump battery backup.

One in four Canadians in a 2026 survey were unsure if their policy covers flood damage. A short call to your broker settles it. (Source 1)

After a leak

- **Contact your insurer promptly.** Many policies ask you to report a loss quickly and take reasonable steps to prevent further damage.
- **Document everything:** photos and video, dates and times, what you noticed, and a list of damaged items with approximate value and age.
- **Keep damaged items** until your insurer says you can dispose of them, unless they are a hazard.
- **Save every receipt** for emergency repairs, drying, temporary accommodation and cleanup.
- **Write down** the claim number, the name of each person you speak to, and what was said.
- **Ask questions** if something is unclear: what is covered, what the deductible is, and what the next steps are.

This guide offers general information only and is not insurance, legal or professional advice. Coverage and requirements depend on your policy, your location and the circumstances of the loss.

Sources

Every number and expert insight in this guide comes from a public source. Figures are from the year shown and may have changed.

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2. Insurance Bureau of Canada, as reported in "Water surpasses fire as the leading cause of home insurance payouts," Insurance Business Canada, May 2017. insurancebusinessmag.com
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6. Intact Centre on Climate Adaptation, "Three Steps to Cost-Effective Basement Flood Protection," 2019. intactcentreclimateadaptation.ca
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8. This Old House, "How to install an automatic washing machine shut-off valve," with Richard Trethewey. thisoldhouse.com
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10. US Environmental Protection Agency, "A Brief Guide to Mold, Moisture and Your Home." epa.gov/mold

The experts named in this guide did not write, review or endorse it. Their ideas are summarized from public work and any errors are ours. US figures are in US dollars; Canadian figures are in Canadian dollars. Illustrations are for guidance only and may not match your home.

Thank you for reading.

A little attention each month goes a long way. We hope you never need page 13, but now you know where it is.

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